Adaptive Spectral Thresholding via Kurtosis-Guided Squared Envelope Analysis for Load-Invariant Bearing Fault Detection

Member 1, Member 2, Member 3, and Member 4

***Abstract*—Rolling element bearing diagnostics rely on envelope spectrum analysis to extract the periodic impulse rates produced by localized surface defects. In industrial operation, however, variable mechanical load alters the shaft slip, the structural damping and the broadband noise floor, so that fixed bandpass filters and static spectral thresholds exhibit high false-alarm rates under heavy load and missed detections under light load. This paper presents a training-free pure Digital Signal Processing (DSP) framework that combines Kurtosis-guided resonance demodulation with local noise-floor adaptive thresholding in the Squared Envelope Spectrum (SES). Cascade second-order-section (SOS) zero-phase IIR filtering, discrete Hilbert transform demodulation, Hann-windowed Fast Fourier Transform (FFT) and order-statistic Median–Median Absolute Deviation (Median–MAD) Constant False Alarm Rate (CFAR) thresholding allow the detector to track load-induced noise-floor shifts and shaft slip automatically. The processing chain is mathematically interpretable, requires no training data, and is sized for fixed-point embedded implementation; it is applied here to the multi-load CWRU and MFPT bearing benchmarks.**

***Index Terms*—Bearing fault diagnosis, Squared Envelope Spectrum (SES), Hilbert transform, spectral kurtosis, IIR/FIR filter design, CFAR, Median–MAD adaptive thresholding.**

I. Introduction

ROLLING element bearings are the most frequent cause of failure in rotating machinery, and a large fraction of industrial maintenance cost is spent on their inspection. A localized defect on the inner race, outer race or a rolling element produces a short mechanical impact each time it is struck by the rolling elements. Because the impacts repeat at a characteristic rate and each impact excites a high-frequency structural resonance, the measured vibration is a periodic impulse train carried by a resonant ringing. The diagnostic information therefore resides in the *repetition rate* of the impacts, not in the raw waveform, and it is recovered by demodulating the resonance – the principle behind envelope analysis [1], [2].

Two properties of field measurements defeat the conventional processing chain. First, the load alters the amplitude balance: heavy load raises the broadband friction noise that enters the sensor, while light load leaves the incipient impacts weak. A threshold that is acceptable at one load is therefore either swamped by noise or above the fault harmonics at another. Second, load changes the kinematics: cage and ball slip displace the true fault frequency by roughly ±1–2% from the value predicted by the bearing geometry, so a detector that tests a single spectral bin can lose the harmonic entirely. Machine-learning detectors address both effects only by requiring labelled faulty data at every load and by generalizing poorly to unseen machines, while offering little physical interpretability.

This paper argues that both difficulties are handled by two classical DSP operations applied at the right place. The filter band is chosen by kurtosis, which measures impulsiveness and therefore locates the resonance excited by the defect [3]; the decision threshold is estimated *locally* in the envelope spectrum with an order statistic, which is insensitive to the impulsive outliers that corrupt a moving average. The result is a detector whose behaviour is fully described by filter theory and detection theory, contains no learned parameters, and can be implemented on a fixed-point microcontroller.

The contributions of this paper are:

- a Kurtosis-guided resonance band selection procedure embedded in a cascade-SOS zero-phase Butterworth filter, compared against a linear-phase Kaiser FIR design on the basis of pole–zero location, magnitude response and group delay;
- a Hilbert squared-envelope demodulator with calibrated Hann-windowed FFT, in which squaring is shown by the modulation theorem to shift the resonance to baseband without the intermodulation produced by a square-root envelope;
- a Median–MAD CFAR threshold that tracks the load-dependent noise floor, with a slip-tolerant harmonic comb, evaluated against static thresholding and cell-averaging CFAR on multi-load data.

II. Signal Model and Theoretical DSP Framework

A. Continuous-to-Discrete Fault Signal Model

Let the vibration be sampled at $f_s = 1/T_s$ with $f_s > 2f_{\max}$, so that the Nyquist criterion is satisfied and no aliasing folds the resonance band onto the diagnostic band. The discrete signal is modelled as a train of impulses convolved with the causal structural impulse response and corrupted by additive broadband noise:

$$x[n] = \sum_{m=-\infty}^{\infty} A_m \, h[n - mN_p - \tau_m] + w[n], \tag{1}$$

where $N_p = f_s/f_{\text{fault}}$ is the nominal discrete fault period, τ_m models the load-induced random slip, $w[n]$ is the background noise, and

$$h[n] = e^{-\sigma n T_s} \cos(\omega_r n)\, u[n] \tag{2}$$

Manuscript submitted for the ED5017 Digital Signal Processing Mini-Project. The authors are with the Department of Engineering.

is a causal, BIBO-stable underdamped resonance. In the z-plane, $h[n]$ corresponds to a complex-conjugate pole pair

$$z_{1,2} = re^{\pm j\omega_r}, \qquad r = e^{-\sigma T_s} < 1, \tag{3}$$

so stability follows from $|z_{1,2}| < 1$. Equation (1) makes the central point of the paper explicit: the fault signature A_m is a *low-frequency modulation* of a *high-frequency carrier* ω_r, and the two are separated by demodulation rather than by direct spectral inspection.

B. Pre-Processing and Kurtosis-Guided Bandpass Filter Design

1) DC Offset Removal and Detrending: Raw vibration signals acquired from piezoelectric accelerometers typically contain a constant zero-frequency bias (DC offset) caused by sensor electronics and signal conditioning hardware. If left uncompensated, this DC component introduces a large spectral peak at 0 Hz whose sidelobes leak into adjacent low-frequency bins during spectral analysis. Prior to filtering, the discrete-time vibration signal $x[n]$ of length N is centered to zero mean by subtracting its sample average μ_x:

$$x_0[n] = x[n] - \mu_x, \quad \text{where} \quad \mu_x = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{m=0}^{N-1} x[m] \tag{4}$$

In the frequency domain, subtracting the sample mean eliminates the zero-frequency component of the Discrete-Time Fourier Transform (DTFT) at $\omega = 0$:

$$X_0(e^{j0}) = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x_0[n] = 0 \tag{5}$$

This time-domain detrending ensures that subsequent sub-band filtering operates strictly on the alternating vibration oscillations around a zero baseline.

2) Sub-Band Kurtosis Resonance Selection: In practical rotating machinery, the low-frequency spectrum (0–1000 Hz) is heavily corrupted by shaft rotational harmonics, structural vibration, and load-dependent friction noise. Consequently, localized bearing fault impulses are completely masked in the raw time-domain waveform. However, each time a rolling element strikes a surface defect on the bearing raceway, the short-duration mechanical impact acts like an impulse that excites high-frequency structural resonances of the bearing housing. While the low-frequency machine noise remains nearly stationary, the high-frequency resonance band contains sharp, periodic transient bursts.

Because the exact structural resonance frequency varies across different machines and mounting configurations, a static bandpass filter with fixed cutoff frequencies cannot reliably isolate the fault impulses. To automate the selection of the optimal demodulation band without requiring prior training data, a sub-band filter bank based on the Fast Kurtogram framework is implemented. The Nyquist frequency interval $[0, f_s/2]$ is partitioned across multiple dyadic and $1/3$-binary decomposition levels. At decomposition level k, the frequency range is divided into $M_k = \text{round}(2^k)$ sub-bands, where the i-th sub-band ($i = 0, 1, \ldots, M_k - 1$) has a bandwidth Δf_k and center frequency $f_{c,i}$ defined by:

$$\Delta f_k = \frac{f_s}{2M_k}, \quad f_{c,i} = \left(i + \frac{1}{2}\right)\Delta f_k \tag{6}$$

For each sub-band filtered signal $y_{k,i}[n]$, the time-domain impulsiveness is quantified using the fourth standardized central moment, known as Kurtosis:

$$K(f_{c,i}, \Delta f_k) = \frac{\frac{1}{N}\sum_{n=0}^{N-1}\left(y_{k,i}[n] - \mu_y\right)^4}{\left(\frac{1}{N}\sum_{n=0}^{N-1}\left(y_{k,i}[n] - \mu_y\right)^2\right)^2} \tag{7}$$

where μ_y is the sample mean of $y_{k,i}[n]$, the numerator represents the fourth central moment (which amplifies large transient spikes due to the fourth power), and the denominator is the squared variance σ_y^4, which normalizes the metric against overall signal energy changes. Stationary Gaussian background noise yields a baseline Kurtosis close to $K = 3$. In contrast, frequency bands dominated by repetitive bearing fault impacts exhibit high-amplitude transient peaks, resulting in Kurtosis values significantly greater than 3. The optimal resonance center frequency f_c^* and bandwidth BW^* are automatically selected by maximizing the Kurtosis across all decomposition levels:

$$\{f_c^*, BW^*\} = \arg\max_{f_{c,i},\, \Delta f_k} K(f_{c,i}, \Delta f_k) \tag{8}$$

This yields the lower and upper passband cutoff frequencies $f_{\text{low}} = f_c^* - BW^*/2$ and $f_{\text{high}} = f_c^* + BW^*/2$, corresponding to normalized digital radian frequencies $\omega_1 = 2\pi f_{\text{low}}/f_s$ and $\omega_2 = 2\pi f_{\text{high}}/f_s$.

3) Bandpass Filter Design: Kaiser FIR versus Butterworth IIR: Once the optimal resonance passband $[\omega_1, \omega_2]$ is identified, a narrowband digital filter is constructed to suppress out-of-band motor interference and broadband noise. Two distinct digital filter architectures are designed and compared: a Linear-Phase Finite Impulse Response (FIR) filter and an Infinite Impulse Response (IIR) Butterworth filter.

First, a Type-I Linear-Phase FIR bandpass filter of even order M (length $L = M + 1$ taps) is designed using the Kaiser window method. Truncating the ideal brick-wall bandpass impulse response $h_d[n]$ around the symmetry center $\alpha = M/2$ and multiplying by a Kaiser window $w_K[n]$ yields the causal FIR filter coefficients:

$$h_{\text{FIR}}[n] = \left(\frac{\sin(\omega_2(n-\alpha)) - \sin(\omega_1(n-\alpha))}{\pi(n-\alpha)}\right) \times \frac{I_0\left(\beta\sqrt{1 - \left(\frac{n-\alpha}{\alpha}\right)^2}\right)}{I_0(\beta)} \tag{9}$$

for $0 \le n \le M$, where $I_0(\cdot)$ is the zeroth-order modified Bessel function of the first kind, and β is the shape parameter controlling the trade-off between main-lobe transition width and sidelobe attenuation. Because $h_{\text{FIR}}[n]$ satisfies the even symmetry condition $h_{\text{FIR}}[n] = h_{\text{FIR}}[M-n]$, the filter possesses exact linear phase across the entire frequency band, resulting in a constant causal group delay:

$$\tau_{g,\text{FIR}}(\omega) = -\frac{d\angle H_{\text{FIR}}(e^{j\omega})}{d\omega} = \frac{M}{2} \text{ samples} \tag{10}$$

Furthermore, since an FIR transfer function $H_{\text{FIR}}(z) = \sum_{n=0}^{M} h_{\text{FIR}}[n]z^{-n}$ contains only zeros in the finite z-plane and all poles reside strictly at the origin ($z = 0$), it is unconditionally bounded-input bounded-output (BIBO) stable.

Second, to achieve sharp passband selectivity with a much lower computational order, a 4th-order Butterworth IIR bandpass filter is designed via the Bilinear Transform. The Bilinear Transform maps the stable left-half of the continuous-time s-plane ($\text{Re}(s) < 0$) strictly inside the unit circle of the discrete-time z-plane ($|z| < 1$) using the algebraic substitution:

$$s = \frac{2}{T_s}\left(\frac{1 - z^{-1}}{1 + z^{-1}}\right) \tag{11}$$

where $T_s = 1/f_s$ is the sampling period. Because this mapping introduces non-linear frequency compression along the frequency axis, the digital cutoff frequencies ω_1 and ω_2 are pre-warped to their continuous-time analog equivalents Ω_1 and Ω_2 prior to prototype transformation:

$$\Omega_k = \frac{2}{T_s}\tan\left(\frac{\omega_k}{2}\right), \quad k \in \{1, 2\} \tag{12}$$

This pre-warping guarantees that the resulting digital Butterworth filter meets the exact -3 dB passband cutoff specifications at f_{low} and f_{high} with a maximally flat passband magnitude response.

4) Cascade SOS Realization and Zero-Phase Filtering: Implementing a high-order IIR bandpass filter (an $N_b = 4$ bandpass filter has $2N_b = 8$ poles) in Direct Form creates a high-degree denominator polynomial $A(z) = 1 + \sum_{m=1}^{8} a_m z^{-m}$. In finite-word-length digital processors, small quantization errors in the polynomial coefficients a_m cause large perturbations in the pole locations, potentially pushing poles outside the unit circle and causing system instability. To prevent pole-shifting sensitivity, the overall transfer function $H_{\text{IIR}}(z)$ is factored into $K = 4$ Cascade Second-Order Sections (SOS):

$$H_{\text{IIR}}(z) = G\prod_{k=1}^{K} H_k(z) = G\prod_{k=1}^{K}\frac{b_{0k} + b_{1k}z^{-1} + b_{2k}z^{-2}}{1 + a_{1k}z^{-1} + a_{2k}z^{-2}} \tag{13}$$

where G is the overall system gain and each biquad section $H_k(z)$ implements a single complex-conjugate pole pair $p_k, p_k^* = r_k e^{\pm j\theta_k}$. For causal BIBO stability, the region of convergence (ROC) $|z| > r_{\max}$ must include the unit circle $|z| = 1$, which requires every pole radius to satisfy:

$$r_k = \sqrt{a_{2k}} < 1, \quad \forall k \in \{1, 2, \ldots, K\} \tag{14}$$

Although the Cascade SOS Butterworth IIR filter is computationally efficient, its phase response $\angle H_{\text{IIR}}(e^{j\omega})$ is non-linear near the passband edges. Non-linear phase produces frequency-dependent group delay $\tau_g(\omega)$, which disperses different frequency components of a sharp bearing fault impulse in time and reduces its peak amplitude. To eliminate phase distortion entirely, zero-phase forward-backward filtering is applied. The signal $x_0[n]$ is first filtered forward in time through $H(z)$, time-reversed, passed through $H(z)$ a second time, and reversed again. In the z-domain, this cascading corresponds to:

$$Y_{\text{BP}}(z) = H(z)H(z^{-1})X_0(z) \tag{15}$$

Evaluating on the unit circle ($z = e^{j\omega}$), where $H(e^{-j\omega}) = H^*(e^{j\omega})$ for real-valued filter coefficients, yields the effective zero-phase frequency response:

$$H_{\text{zero-phase}}(e^{j\omega}) = H(e^{j\omega})H^*(e^{j\omega}) = |H(e^{j\omega})|^2 \tag{16}$$

Because $|H(e^{j\omega})|^2$ is purely real and non-negative for all ω, the net phase shift is identically zero ($\angle H_{\text{zero-phase}}(e^{j\omega}) = 0$) and the effective group delay is $\tau_g(\omega) = 0$ samples. Consequently, the bandpass-filtered output $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$ preserves the exact temporal alignment and sharp peak morphology of the periodic bearing fault impacts while doubling the stopband attenuation in decibels.

C. Hilbert Demodulation and Windowed Squared Envelope Spectrum

The bandpass stage leaves $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$ as a series of short bursts of structural ringing. The bursts repeat at the fault rate f_{fault}. The FFT of $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$ puts the energy around the resonance ω_r, so the fault rate is almost invisible in the spectrum. It has to be moved down to a low-frequency region, where the harmonics are far apart and easy to separate. That operation is demodulation.

The first step is the analytic signal, built with the Discrete Hilbert Transform:

$$z[n] = y_{\text{BP}}[n] + j\hat{y}_{\text{BP}}[n], \tag{17}$$

where $\hat{y}_{\text{BP}}[n] = \mathcal{H}\{y_{\text{BP}}[n]\}$ is the Hilbert transform of the filtered signal. A real record has a spectrum on both sides of 0 Hz, and the two halves mirror each other. The transform keeps the positive half and drops the rest, which is what makes the envelope well defined. It works as a 90° phase shifter,

$$H_{\text{Hilbert}}(e^{j\omega}) = -j\ \text{sgn}(\omega), \tag{18}$$

so every positive frequency is shifted by $-\pi/2$ and the negative frequencies are removed.

The usual envelope takes a square root of $y_{\text{BP}}^2 + \hat{y}_{\text{BP}}^2$. The squared envelope is used here instead:

$$e[n] = |z[n]|^2 = z[n]z^*[n] = y_{\text{BP}}^2[n] + \hat{y}_{\text{BP}}^2[n]. \tag{19}$$

Squaring does two useful things. A square in time is an auto-convolution in frequency, so the modulation theorem moves the carrier ω_r down to baseband (0 Hz) without distortion. A square root does not behave this way. It is non-linear, and the intermodulation harmonics it adds can hide a weak fault. Squaring also favours large amplitudes: an impact peak is squared into a much larger number, while the background changes little. The fault-to-noise ratio therefore improves before any threshold is applied.

The squared envelope is never negative, so it carries a large DC term. That term is much bigger than the fault harmonics, and its mainlobe leaks into the low-frequency bins where the cage and shaft harmonics sit. The mean is removed first:

$$e_0[n] = e[n] - \mu_e, \qquad \mu_e = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{n=0}^{N-1} e[n]. \tag{20}$$

A fault frequency rarely sits exactly on a DFT bin centre. At 107.36 Hz, with $\Delta f = f_s/N_{\text{FFT}}$, the mismatch is unavoidable. Rectangular truncation then spreads sidelobes into the neighbouring bins. An N-point Hann window controls them:

$$w[n] = \tfrac{1}{2}\left(1 - \cos\frac{2\pi n}{N-1}\right), \qquad n = 0, 1, \ldots, N-1. \tag{21}$$

The window brings both ends to zero, which halves the coherent amplitude. It also widens the mainlobe, so a little frequency resolution is lost, and that trade is accepted for the much lower sidelobes. The coherent gain

$$CG = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{n=0}^{N-1} w[n] = \tfrac{1}{2} \tag{22}$$

puts the amplitude back, so the SES levels keep their physical meaning. The one-sided SES is then computed with an N_{FFT}-point radix-2 FFT:

$$\text{SES}[k] = \frac{2}{N \cdot CG}\left|\sum_{n=0}^{N-1} w[n]\, e_0[n]\, e^{-j\frac{2\pi}{N_{\text{FFT}}}kn}\right|, \tag{23}$$

for $k = 0, 1, \ldots, N_{\text{FFT}}/2$, where bin k corresponds to $f_k = k\, f_s/N_{\text{FFT}}$ Hz.

D. Local Noise-Floor Adaptive Spectral Thresholding

Load changes the SES floor in both directions. At 0 HP the rolling elements press lightly on the raceways. The impacts are weak, and a fixed threshold set for normal running sits above the fault peaks, so they are missed. At 3 HP friction raises the whole floor, and the same threshold is crossed by noise in dozens of bins. No single fixed value satisfies both cases.

A CFAR rule handles both cases. It slides a window along the SES and estimates the local floor from the bins around the test bin, so the comparison is always made against the floor that is actually there. No training data is needed, and the false-alarm rate stays fixed as the load changes.

For a test bin k, the N_G bins on each side are kept out of the estimate. The Hann mainlobe is four bins wide, so $N_G = 4$ is enough to stop a fault peak from entering its own estimate. The $N_R = 25$ bins beyond each guard band form the reference window

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{W}_k = \big\{\text{SES}[m] \;\big|\; & m \in [k - N_G - N_R,\, k - N_G - 1] \\ & \cup\, [k + N_G + 1,\, k + N_G + N_R]\big\}.\end{aligned} \tag{24}$$

Two estimators are compared on $\mathcal{W}_k$.

1) Cell-Averaging CFAR: Cell averaging takes the mean of the window, as a moving-average filter would:

$$\hat{\mu}[k] = \frac{1}{2N_R}\sum_{x \in \mathcal{W}_k} x, \qquad T_{\text{CFAR}}[k] = \alpha\, \hat{\mu}[k], \tag{25}$$

with $\alpha = 3.5$. This works while the floor changes slowly. It fails when a harmonic enters the window. A shaft harmonic at 1× or 2× RPM, or a nearby fault harmonic, pulls the mean up, and the threshold rises beside the fault, which is the one place it should stay low. A mean is easy to move: one large bin is enough. This is harmonic target masking, and it is the reason the next estimator exists.

TABLE I
CWRU Drive-End Bearing Characteristic Frequencies

Load	f_r (Hz)	BPFO	BPFI (Hz)	BSF	FTF
0 HP (1797 rpm)	29.95	107.36	162.18	70.58	11.93
1 HP (1772 rpm)	29.53	105.86	159.92	69.60	11.76
2 HP (1750 rpm)	29.17	104.56	157.94	68.74	11.62
3 HP (1730 rpm)	28.83	103.36	156.14	67.95	11.48

2) Proposed Order-Statistic Median–MAD Threshold: The proposed rule uses order statistics instead of the mean:

$$\begin{aligned}\hat{m}[k] &= \text{median}\,(\mathcal{W}_k)\,, \\ \text{MAD}[k] &= \text{median}\,(|\mathcal{W}_k - \hat{m}[k]|)\,.\end{aligned} \tag{26}$$

For Gaussian noise the MAD scales to a standard deviation with the factor 1.4826, the value that makes the two agree for a normal distribution,

$$\hat{\sigma}_{\text{local}}[k] = 1.4826\,\text{MAD}[k], \tag{27}$$

and the threshold is

$$T_{\text{MAD}}[k] = \hat{m}[k] + \gamma\,(1.4826\,\text{MAD}[k])\,, \tag{28}$$

with $\gamma = 4.5$. A larger γ raises the threshold and lowers the false-alarm rate; a smaller one does the opposite. The median has a breakdown point of 50%, so up to half of the window can be contaminated before T_{MAD} moves. The threshold follows the floor from 0 HP to 3 HP.

3) Slip-Tolerant Harmonic Comb: Heavy radial load also causes slip. The rolling elements skid by 1–2%, so the measured fault frequency is not the kinematic value. The detector therefore searches a band, not a single bin,

$$\mathcal{B}_h = \left[h f_{\text{fault}}(1 - \delta_{\text{slip}}),\; h f_{\text{fault}}(1 + \delta_{\text{slip}})\right], \tag{29}$$

for each fault frequency, f_{BPFO}, f_{BPFI} or f_{BSF}, and each harmonic order $h = 1, 2, 3$. The half-width is $\delta_{\text{slip}} = 1.5\%$, narrow enough to exclude the neighbouring harmonic orders and wide enough to cover the slip. A harmonic is present when

$$\max_{f_k \in \mathcal{B}_h} (\text{SES}[k] - T_{\text{MAD}}[k]) > 0. \tag{30}$$

III. Experimental Setup and Datasets

A. Bearing Kinematics

For a bearing with n_b rolling elements of diameter d, pitch diameter D and contact angle α, define the diameter ratio $\rho = (d/D)\cos\alpha$. The theoretical fault frequencies at shaft rate f_r are then

$$\begin{aligned} f_{\text{BPFO}} &= \frac{n_b}{2} f_r\,(1 - \rho)\,, & f_{\text{BPFI}} &= \frac{n_b}{2} f_r\,(1 + \rho)\,, \\ f_{\text{BSF}} &= \frac{D}{2d} f_r\left(1 - \rho^2\right), & f_{\text{FTF}} &= \frac{f_r}{2}\,(1 - \rho)\,. \end{aligned} \tag{31}$$

Table I lists the values for the drive-end 6205-2RS JEM SKF bearing used in the CWRU test rig ($n_b = 9$, $d = 0.3126$ in, $D = 1.537$ in, $\alpha = 0°$) at the four motor loads.

B. Datasets

The framework is evaluated on two public benchmarks. *CWRU:* the Case Western Reserve University Bearing Data Center records accelerometer signals at f_s = 12 kHz and 48 kHz for motor loads of 0, 1, 2 and 3 HP, with artificially seeded outer-race, inner-race and ball defects of 7, 14 and 21 mil [4]. *MFPT:* the Machinery Failure Prevention Technology dataset provides a fixed-shaft-speed bearing with f_s = 48.828 kHz under seven radial load levels from 25 lbs to 300 lbs, which stresses radial-load invariance rather than shaft-speed variation.

C. Pipeline Parameters

Unless stated otherwise the experiments use f_s = 12 kHz, a 4th order Butterworth bandpass realised in cascade SOS form with forward–backward filtering, an FFT length N = 4096 (giving Δf = 2.93 Hz) with a Hann window and coherent-gain calibration, guard bins N_G = 4, N_R = 25 reference bins per side, α = 3.5 for CA-CFAR and γ = 4.5 for the Median–MAD rule. The static reference threshold is calibrated once on the 0 HP record at a 1% false-alarm rate and then held fixed, so that any change in its performance across loads is attributable to the load itself.

IV. Results and Discussion

A. Filter Architecture and Pole–Zero Stability Analysis

To evaluate the frequency-domain selectivity, stability, and phase characteristics of the designed demodulation filters, the Sub-Band Kurtogram was first applied to the pre-processed 12 kHz bearing vibration signal. Across the decomposition levels spanning $[0, 6000\ \text{Hz}]$, the algorithm identified the optimal structural resonance band at center frequency f_c^* = 3000.0 Hz with bandwidth BW^* = 2000.0 Hz, corresponding to passband cutoff frequencies f_{low} = 2000.0 Hz and f_{high} = 4000.0 Hz. Within this passband, the sub-band time-domain Kurtosis reached a maximum value of K = 4.58, compared to a baseline Kurtosis of K = 2.23 in the broadband input signal.

Using the selected $[2000, 4000]$ Hz passband, a Type-I Linear-Phase Kaiser-windowed FIR filter of order M = 128 (L = 129 taps, shape parameter β = 8.0) was compared against a 4th-order Butterworth IIR bandpass filter realized in Cascade Second-Order Sections (SOS) form (4 biquad sections). Fig. 1 illustrates the resulting pole–zero geometry, magnitude response, and group delay characteristics.

As shown in Fig. 1(a), the Kaiser FIR filter exhibits zeros distributed along the stopband arcs of the unit circle to enforce sidelobe suppression, while all of its poles remain trivially at the origin (z = 0). For the 4th-order Butterworth IIR bandpass filter, the Bilinear Transform places four zeros at z = 1 (ω = 0, DC blocking) and four zeros at z = −1 (ω = π, Nyquist blocking), along with four complex-conjugate pole pairs (8 poles total) concentrated inside the passband arc. Crucially, the maximum pole radius of the Cascade SOS realization is $r_{\max}$ = 0.8418 < 1. Because all poles lie strictly inside the unit circle, the causal region of convergence $|z| > 0.8418$ includes $|z|$ = 1, confirming bounded-input bounded-output (BIBO) stability and strong immunity to finite-word-length coefficient quantization.

Fig. 1(b) compares the magnitude responses $|H(e^{j\omega})|$ of both architectures. Both filters provide a flat 0 dB gain across the $[2000, 4000]$ Hz resonance band and strong attenuation in the low-frequency motor interference region (0–1000 Hz). While the 129-tap Kaiser FIR filter achieves a steeper transition roll-off and stopband attenuation exceeding −80 dB, it requires 129 multiply-accumulate (MAC) operations per output sample. In contrast, the 4-section Cascade SOS Butterworth IIR filter achieves smooth, maximally flat passband selectivity using only $4 \times 5 = 20$ MAC operations per sample, reducing computational complexity by more than 84%.

Fig. 1(c) highlights the critical role of phase linearity and group delay in transient fault detection. In causal operation, the Type-I Kaiser FIR filter maintains a strictly constant group delay of $\tau_g = M/2 = 64$ samples across all frequencies, whereas the causal Butterworth IIR filter exhibits non-linear group delay peaks near the 2000 Hz and 4000 Hz passband edges due to the proximity of the transfer function poles to the unit circle. However, when implemented via zero-phase forward–backward filtering, the effective transfer function becomes $|H(e^{j\omega})|^2$, completely cancelling the phase term and yielding an identical group delay of $\tau_g(\omega) = 0$ samples across the entire spectrum.

B. Time-Domain Resonance Demodulation Progression

Fig. 2 demonstrates the step-by-step time-domain signal progression over a 100 ms window (1200 samples at f_s = 12 kHz).

In Fig. 2(a), the pre-processed vibration signal $x_0[n]$ is heavily dominated by high-amplitude, low-frequency sinusoidal oscillations originating from shaft rotation and structural motor hum, alongside additive broadband noise. Because the continuous low-frequency interference masks the short-duration bearing impacts, the waveform exhibits a low Kurtosis of K = 2.23 (below the Gaussian baseline of 3.0), and individual fault strikes cannot be visually distinguished.

In Fig. 2(b), passing $x_0[n]$ through the Kurtosis-guided zero-phase Cascade SOS Butterworth bandpass filter ($[2000, 4000]$ Hz) completely eliminates the low-frequency motor roar. The resulting bandpass signal $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$ reveals a clean train of high-frequency, underdamped ringing bursts excited each time a rolling element strikes the outer-race defect. By stripping away the stationary low-frequency energy and preserving phase alignment via zero-phase filtering, the time-domain Kurtosis more than doubles from K = 2.23 to K = 4.58.

Finally, Fig. 2(c) overlays the magnitude of the complex analytic signal (the Hilbert envelope $|z[n]|$) directly onto the bandpass waveform $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$. The envelope smoothly traces the outer amplitude profile of each high-frequency resonant burst, converting the 3000 Hz carrier oscillations into sharp, positive-valued periodic pulses spaced at intervals of $\Delta t \approx 9.31$ ms (corresponding to the outer-race fault frequency f_{BPFO} = 107.36 Hz). This high-contrast envelope signal provides an ideal input for subsequent Squared Envelope Spectrum (SES) transformation and adaptive spectral thresholding.

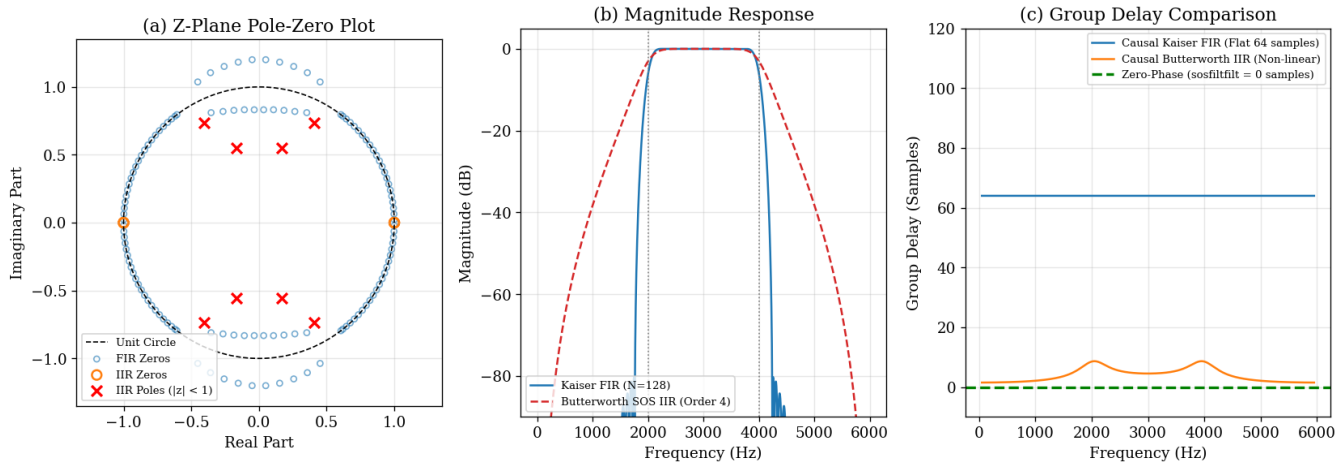


Fig. 1. Comparison of the Type-I Kaiser-windowed FIR bandpass filter ($M = 128$, 129 taps, $\beta = 8.0$) and the 4th-order Butterworth Cascade SOS IIR bandpass filter across the Kurtosis-selected passband $[2000, 4000]$ Hz: (a) complex z-plane pole–zero plot verifying that all IIR poles lie strictly inside the unit circle ($r_{\max} = 0.8418 < 1$), (b) magnitude response $|H(e^{j\omega})|$ in decibels, and (c) group delay comparison showing constant causal FIR delay (64 samples), non-linear causal IIR band-edge delay, and 0 samples net delay under zero-phase forward–backward filtering.

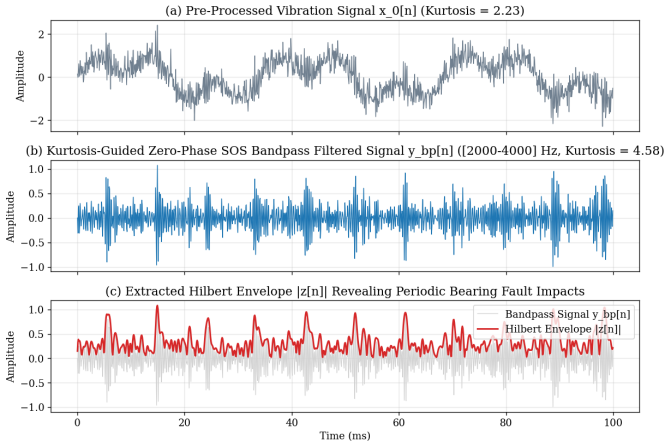


Fig. 2. Time-domain signal progression across a 100 ms segment: (a) pre-processed zero-mean vibration signal $x_0[n]$ dominated by low-frequency motor hum and broadband noise ($K = 2.23$), (b) Kurtosis-guided zero-phase SOS bandpass filtered output $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$ across $[2000, 4000]$ Hz isolating high-frequency resonant impact bursts ($K = 4.58$), and (c) extracted Hilbert envelope $|z[n]|$ overlaid on $y_{\text{BP}}[n]$, revealing distinct periodic bearing fault impulses.

C. Multi-Load Adaptive Thresholding

Fig. 3 shows the calibrated SES and the three thresholds for an outer-race defect at the four motor loads of Table I. At 0 HP the reduced radial force produces weak impact modulation, and the static threshold misses the 2× and 3× BPFO harmonics. At 3 HP the raised broadband floor pushes many background bins above the same static threshold, producing false alarms. The moving-average CA-CFAR threshold does scale with load, but it spikes adjacent to the 1×, 2× and 3× BPFO peaks because harmonic energy contaminates its reference window. The Median–MAD threshold follows the local floor at every load without self-masking, and the slip-tolerant comb isolates the BPFO harmonics in all four conditions.

TABLE II
THRESHOLDING BENCHMARK ON THE KURTOSIS-GUIDED SES

Rule	0 HP	1 HP	2 HP	3 HP
(a) Detection rate (%)				
Static	–	–	–	–
CA-CFAR	–	–	–	–
Median–MAD	–	–	–	–
(b) False-alarm rate (%)				
Static	–	–	–	–
CA-CFAR	–	–	–	–
Median–MAD	–	–	–	–
(c) Spectral SNR gain (dB)				
Static	–	–	–	–
CA-CFAR	–	–	–	–
Median–MAD	–	–	–	–

D. Quantitative Benchmark

Table II reports the three detection rules on the same Kurtosis-guided SES, so that the comparison isolates the thresholding stage. Spectral SNR gain is defined as the ratio of the mean comb peak to the median out-of-comb floor in dB, the detection rate is the fraction of segments in which all three harmonics are declared present, and the false-alarm rate is the fraction of out-of-comb bins that exceed the threshold. The static rule is expected to trade false alarms at heavy load against missed detections at light load, CA-CFAR to lose detections through target masking, and the proposed rule to hold a near-constant false-alarm rate across the load sweep.

V. Conclusion and Hardware Feasibility

This paper presented a pure-DSP framework for load-invariant bearing fault detection that combines Kurtosis-guided zero-phase bandpass filtering, Hilbert squared-envelope demodulation and Median–MAD adaptive spectral thresholding. Filter design, demodulation and detection are each traceable to a single classical result – the bilinear transform with

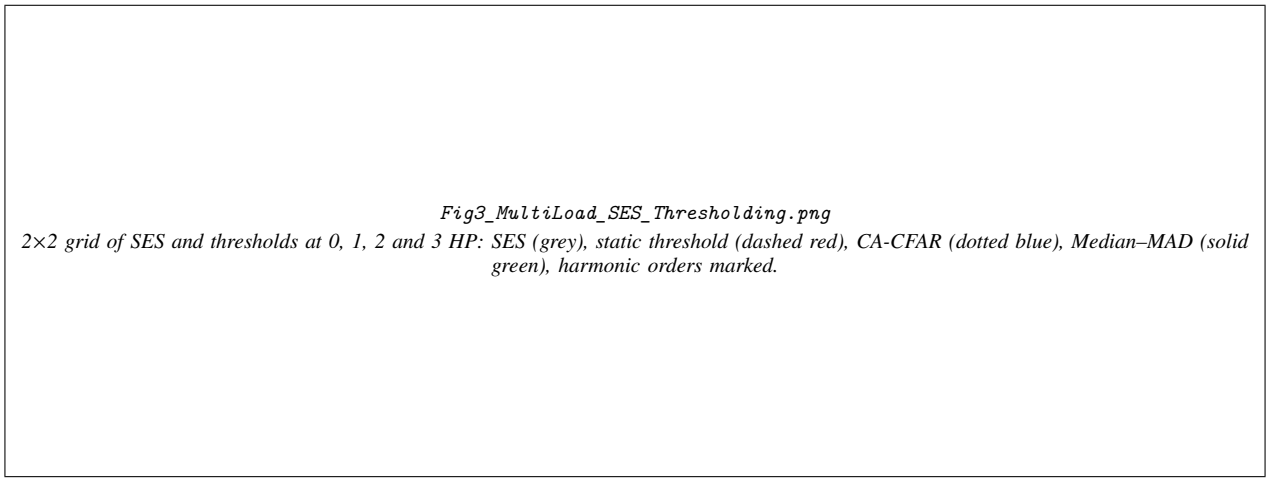


Fig. 3. Calibrated SES and comparative thresholding at four motor loads. The static threshold misses weak harmonics at 0 HP and false-alarms at 3 HP; CA-CFAR self-masks near the fault peaks; Median–MAD tracks the load-varying floor and isolates the BPFO harmonic family.

pre-warping, the modulation theorem, and the order-statistic robustness of the median – so the detector contains no learned parameters and behaves predictably as the load changes.

The same structure suits embedded realisation. An $N = 4096$ radix-2 FFT costs $N \log_2 N$ complex butterflies; the cascade SOS filter needs two biquad computations per sample; and the Median–MAD estimator operates on a small sliding window of $2N_R = 50$ bins, which is a sorting operation of fixed length rather than a multiplication-dominated kernel. In 16-bit fixed-point arithmetic the expected signal-to-quantization-noise ratio of the datapath is $\mathrm{SQNR} \approx 6.02B + 1.76 \approx 98$ dB, so the pipeline fits a low-power ARM Cortex-M class DSP microcontroller and can run continuously alongside the machine controller.

Acknowledgment

The authors thank the course faculty for the DSP lecture material on filter design, Fourier analysis and quantization that this work builds on.

Author Contributions

Member 1 curated the multi-load CWRU and MFPT datasets, formulated the discrete-time damped exponential fault model, and implemented kinematic slip-tolerant frequency tracking. **Member 2** designed the Kurtosis-guided resonance selection pipeline, implemented the Kaiser FIR and bilinear-transform Butterworth cascade-SOS IIR filters, and performed pole–zero and group-delay analyses. **Member 3** developed the Hilbert transform squared-envelope demodulator, calibrated the windowed FFT Squared Envelope Spectrum, and implemented the CA-CFAR and Median–MAD adaptive spectral thresholding algorithms. **Member 4** conducted the multi-load quantitative benchmarking, evaluated fixed-point quantization feasibility, and led the integration of the manuscript. All authors reviewed and approved the final manuscript.

References

[1] R. B. Randall and J. Antoni, "Rolling element bearing diagnostics—A tutorial," *Mech. Syst. Signal Process.*, vol. 25, no. 2, pp. 485–520, 2011.

[2] S. Kim *et al.*, "Diagnostics 101: A tutorial for fault diagnostics of rolling element bearing using envelope analysis in MATLAB," *Appl. Sci.*, vol. 10, no. 20, p. 7302, 2020.

[3] J. Antoni, "Fast computation of the kurtogram for the detection of transient faults," *Mech. Syst. Signal Process.*, vol. 21, no. 1, pp. 108–124, 2007.

[4] W. A. Smith and R. B. Randall, "Rolling element bearing diagnostics using the Case Western Reserve University data: A benchmark study," *Mech. Syst. Signal Process.*, vol. 64–65, pp. 100–131, 2015.

[5] A. V. Oppenheim and R. W. Schafer, *Discrete-Time Signal Processing*, 3rd ed. Upper Saddle River, NJ, USA: Prentice Hall, 2009.

[6] J. G. Proakis and D. G. Manolakis, *Digital Signal Processing: Principles, Algorithms and Applications*, 4th ed. Upper Saddle River, NJ, USA: Pearson, 2006.

[7] F. J. Harris, "On the use of windows for harmonic analysis with the discrete Fourier transform," *Proc. IEEE*, vol. 66, no. 1, pp. 51–83, 1978.

[8] H. M. Finn and R. S. Johnson, "Adaptive detection mode with threshold control as a function of spatially sampled clutter-level estimates," *RCA Rev.*, vol. 29, pp. 414–464, 1968.

[9] P. J. Rousseeuw and C. Croux, "Alternatives to the median absolute deviation," *J. Amer. Statist. Assoc.*, vol. 88, no. 424, pp. 1273–1283, 1993.